BJP'S HARYANA HURRICANE

ITS STUPENDOUS WIN IN THE STATE REJUVENATES THE CADRE AND HANDS THE PARTY A READY TEMPLATE TO FOLLOW IN THE UPCOMING POLLS IN MAHARASHTRA AND JHARKHAND

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VOTER VERDICT
PM Narendra Modi celebrates the BJP's win with party national president J.P. Nadda and Union ministers Rajnath Singh and Amit Shah in New Delhi, Oct. 8

HARDIK CHHABRA

LATE IN THE EVENING OF OCTOBER 8, even as the euphoria over the surprise victory in Haryana was still sinking in, Prime Minister Narendra Modi followed a tradition he has set in place after every important election win—appearing at the BJP headquarters in the national capital to address jubilant party workers. After the party agonisingly fell short of the majority mark in the Lok Sabha election in June, the mood had turned sombre and introspective. But now, with the miraculous 'hat-trick of assembly wins' in Haryana and the creditable performance in Jammu and Kashmir, the *josh* is back among BJP workers.

Needless to say, the poll outcomes have rejuvenated the party cadre everywhere. The news was especially heartwarming for them as Haryana was one of the states where the party's Lok Sabha tally had been halved, down from 10 in 2019 to five this year. The result also turned on its head the theory that the 'Modi effect' works better in a state in the national election than during the assembly poll. The template that the BJP followed in Haryana could be invaluable in the forthcoming assembly elections as well. Maharashtra is next in line and, as in Haryana, the BJP had not found it to be a happy hunting ground in May. The party and its allies won just 17 of the state's 48 parliamentary seats with an antagonistic Maratha community, factionalism and mounting anger against deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis all working against the ruling Mahayuti alliance. It had fared relatively better in Jharkhand, with the NDA winning nine of the state's 14 LS seats, but here again the BJP will have to work hard to regain the affections of the angry tribal communities while also reining in the massive factionalism.

What the Haryana win has demonstrated is that the party leadership is not averse to course correction. Also, that the party's Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) base